SHAHIDUL ALAM







WITH LUCID LENSES
From left, A mural in Dhaka's Jahangirnagar University; Bangladesh's first collective of women photographers; floodwaters in Dhaka

SHAHIDUL ALAM'S AFFINITY with Kolkata runs deep. His parents lived and got married here. The acclaimed photojournalist came to the city shortly after Bangladesh was liberated in 1971: "We saw three films a day and went to every concert we could fit in." Crucially, many of the artists, philosophers, poets and activists the 67-year-old admires all have a Kolkata link. It seems only fitting that *Singed but Not Burnt*, Alam's first Asian retrospective, has come here before curator Ina Puri travels the country with it. This city is no stranger to revolution, and Alam's work hits home with the force of a sledgehammer.

Alam took to photography by accident. While he was on a hitchhiking trip in the US, a friend asked Alam to buy him a camera. "He didn't have the money, so I got stuck with it," Alam tells INDIA TODAY over email. The photographer's early work—nudes, photos of forests and swans—sees him use his Nikon FM to frame beauty, mostly radically but, sometimes, also conventionally. The photos he takes as a chemistry doctoral student in London seem more concerned with aesthetics, while the pictures he makes on his return to Bangladesh, especially those from the late '80s, demand a new ethic.

"It wasn't a shift," clarifies Alam. "The ethics is the message, the aesthetics is the means. In the UK, the cause was not as acute. In Bangladesh, it was all consuming." On display at Emami Art until August 20, *Singed...* can suddenly grab you by the collar. Whether it's a woman being forced to cook on her tin roof, or another wading through a flooded Dhaka, people are battling the odds everywhere. The dots of Alam's photography all connect to prove an obvious truth—people are invariably resilient in the face of adversity, but their peril is often brought about by the apathy and hubris of those in power.

It seems hardly surprising that a Shahidul Alam retrospective offers us, his Indian audience, a snapshot of Bangladeshi history, but one feels that *Singed...* is also trying to remind us that history, much like a cliche, repeats itself again and again. In 1990, Alam shoots men atop a truck, celebrating the fall of General Hussain Muhammad Ershad's military dictatorship. In a 1991 photo, we see Begum Khaleda Zia surrounded by women at an election rally, and hope seems palpable. But later, when Alam again goes to photograph Zia, he is met by a wall of burly men. The prime minister is distant, almost invisible.

Alam isn't frustrated by such irony. He says, "Frustration is a luxury one cannot afford. The minute you say, 'What's the use?', and give up, you've abdicated. Not only do I refuse to give them an easy passage, I refuse to give them respite. The stakes are much too high." In Alam's case, it seems clear that he doesn't employ the 'us-and-them' formulation lightly. It is the State which has drawn that line in the sand. During Ershad's regime, he'd seen a loaded gun pointed to his head. He was later stabbed eight times, and, then, on August 5, 2018, Alam suffered an ordeal which was in some part Kafkaesque.

After two teenagers were killed by speeding buses in Dhaka, thousands of students took to the streets, demanding their roads be safer. Seeing the police fire tear gas and rubber bullets, Alam live-streamed the protest on Facebook. On August 5, the same day he had told *Al Jazeera* that he'd seen police officials simply look on as armed gangs assaulted students, he was ar-

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